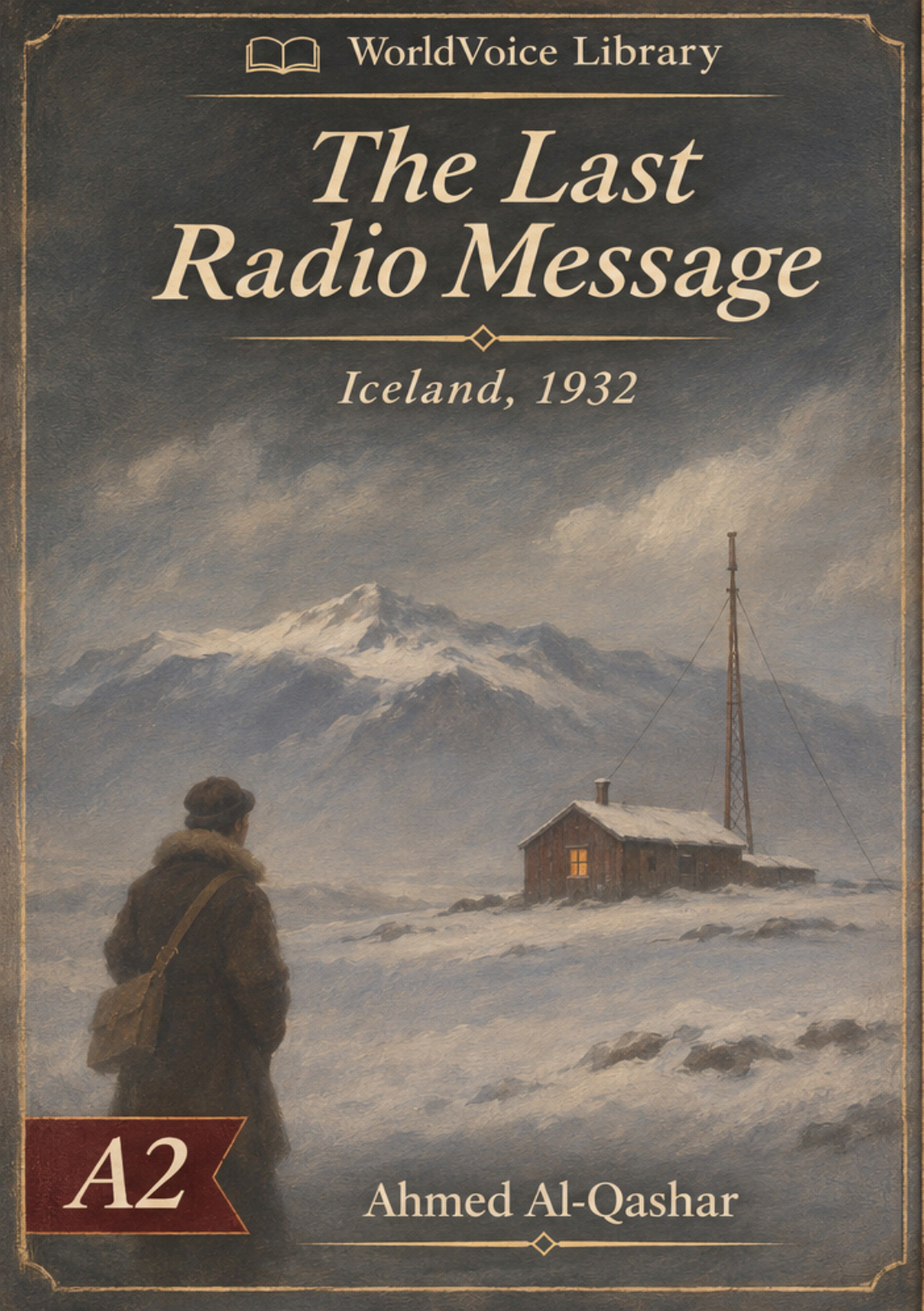
WorldVoice Library

The Last Radio Message

Iceland, 1932



A2

Ahmed Al-Qashar

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English Graded Reader · Level A2

About This Book

The Last Radio Message is an original work of fiction for WorldVoice Library. Its people, research station, and events are invented. It is set in Iceland in 1932. The story uses an elementary English reading level (A2), with simple conversations and useful vocabulary.

This book contains nine chapters, illustrations, a glossary of forty words, comprehension and discussion questions, a writing task, a final test, and an answer key.

Written by Ahmed Al-Qashar. WorldVoice Library · Original fiction · 2026.

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Before You Read

In winter, four people travel toward a remote scientific station in Iceland. A broken radio message is the only sign that something may be wrong. As they search for the truth, they learn that listening, measuring, and helping one another are as important as being brave.

A Think About It

1. Why do people send emergency messages?

2. What problems can snow and ice cause on a journey?

3. Can a short message be more important than a long conversation? Why?

B Key Words

Match the words to the meanings: signal, glacier, warning, guide, repair.

a. make something work again b. a person who shows the way c. a radio or other message

d. a large moving body of ice e. information about danger

Characters



Tom Carter

A young radio engineer who listens carefully, repairs broken machines, and writes down every important word.



Elin Bjornsdottir

An Icelandic scientist who studies ice and water. She asks questions and checks facts before making decisions.



Dr. Erik Hansen

An experienced researcher who knows the North Ridge station and keeps careful notebooks.



Jonas

A local mountain guide who understands the paths, the weather, and the people who live in the valley.

Contents

About This Book 3
Before You Read 4
Characters 5
Contents 6
Chapter 1 A Voice in the Static 7
Chapter 2 The Red Line on the Map 10
Chapter 3 Across the White Plain 13
Chapter 4 The Station Without a Voice 16
Chapter 5 Footprints on the Ice 19
Chapter 6 Warm Water, Cold Stone 22
Chapter 7 The Village by the River 25
Chapter 8 The Last Radio Message 31
Chapter 9 A Clear Morning 34
Vocabulary - 40 Useful Words 37
Comprehension Questions 39
True or False? 41
Vocabulary Practice 42
Discussion Questions 43
Writing Task 44
Final Test 45
Answer Key 47

CHAPTER 1

A Voice in the Static

In the little town of Hrafnvik, the winter day ended early. Snow lay on the road, on the fishing boats, and on the low roof of the radio office. People closed their shops before dark. Only the light above the radio desk was still on. Tom Carter sat with his headphones over his ears. He had come to Iceland to repair radio equipment. Now he helped the town send weather reports and important messages.

Outside, the wind pushed snow against the window. Inside, the room was warm, but Tom could hear the cold weather in every sound from the aerial. The radio made a long, rough noise. Sometimes a ship spoke from the sea. Sometimes a town sent news. Tom wrote down each message in a thick black book. At ten minutes past eight he took off one headphone and reached for his cup of tea. Then a very weak voice came through the noise.



"Hrafnvik. Do you hear me?" the voice said. Tom put the headphone back. "This is North Ridge Station. We need help." The words broke apart. Tom moved a dial slowly and asked the voice to repeat. He heard three more words: "Water ... under ... ice." After that, there were only short sounds, like someone tapping a table. The signal disappeared before Tom could learn the speaker's name. He wrote the words in his book and looked at the clock.

North Ridge was a small research station near a glacier, many hours from the town. A team worked there in summer, measuring snow and stones. In winter, only two scientists stayed. Tom had visited the place once. It was a wooden building with a tall aerial and one narrow road leading to it. There was no telephone line. A radio message could be the only way to ask for help.

Tom tried the station again. "North Ridge, this is Hrafnvik. Can you hear me?" He waited a full minute. The only answer was the sound of the wind across his aerial. Tom checked the battery, the wires, and the dial. His radio was working. He sent the same call three more times. On the fourth try he heard three little taps, then silence. Were they part of a message, or only noise? He did not know.

He put on his coat and crossed the dark street to the house of Dr. Erik Hansen. Erik was a scientist who had worked at North Ridge the year before. He opened the door with a book in his hand. His expression changed when Tom told him what he had heard. "Water under ice," he repeated. "That is not an ordinary weather report." He asked for the exact time and the exact words. Tom was glad he had written them down.

Erik called for Elin Bjornsdottir, a young Icelandic scientist who understood the valley better than anyone in town. She arrived with snow on her scarf and examined Tom's notes under the lamp. "There is a river under part of the glacier," she said. "Most days we cannot see it. But warm water can change the ice. The river might grow much larger." Erik asked whether a large river could reach Hrafnvik. Elin did not answer immediately. She asked to see a map.

They spread a map across the kitchen table. Elin placed her finger on a white area between two dark mountains. "The station is here. The river runs south, toward the farms, before it turns to the sea. If the water rises quickly, the lower road will disappear." Tom looked at the dots that marked small houses near the river. He thought of the families sleeping inside them. "Then we must tell them," he said. Elin shook her head. "First we need to know if the danger is real. We must listen again."

They returned to the radio office together. The room was colder now, and frost had grown at the corners of the glass. Tom turned the dial carefully. A faint clicking sound came through the headphones: three taps, a pause, and three more taps. Elin leaned close to the receiver. "Those are deliberate," she said. "Someone is trying to reach us." Tom took a clean sheet of paper and waited for the next sound. Far away, behind the hills, a person was still sending a message into the night.

CHAPTER 2

The Red Line on the Map

By morning, snow covered the steps of the radio office. Tom had slept for only an hour. He and Elin had listened through most of the night, but the station had sent no clear words. Erik arrived carrying a leather case of notebooks and old maps. Behind him came Jonas, a local guide with a quiet voice and boots that had seen many winters. Jonas knew the hills, the farms, and the narrow tracks beyond them. When he heard the name North Ridge, he took off his hat.

"The road will be difficult," Jonas said. "There was new snow last night, and the wind has moved it across the pass." Erik opened the case. He took out a drawing of the mountain valley, made by the research team the previous autumn. Thin blue lines showed streams. Brown lines showed high ground. Near the bottom of the page was a village called South Meadow. Only forty people lived there, but their houses stood close to the river.



Elin placed a red pencil beside one of the blue lines. "The old river leaves the glacier here," she said. "If it has a new path under the ice, it may reach the village before anyone sees water from the road." Tom remembered the strange message. "Water under ice," he repeated. "Maybe the scientists have found something changing." Erik opened another notebook. Its pages held dates, temperatures, and careful little drawings of cracks in the snow.

"We took measurements at North Ridge last September," Erik said. "The ice was moving more quickly than before. That does not always mean danger. Ice moves all the time. But we planned to watch the river through winter." He pointed to an empty place in the notebook. The last measurement was six weeks old. "I wrote to the station twice. The weather stopped the post. We have no recent numbers." He looked worried, but he did not pretend to know more than he knew.

Tom asked why North Ridge could not send a longer message. Elin explained that snow could damage the aerial, and the station used an old battery. "They may have enough power for only a few words." Tom thought about the three taps. "What if they know we hear them?" He turned on the receiver and pressed the switch. His call went out over the empty white country. "North Ridge, we are listening. Send one short word, slowly." They waited with their heads close together.

At first there was nothing. Then a broken voice said, "Bridge." A long breath of noise followed. Another word came, clearer than the first: "Before." The speaker tried once more, but the sound died. Tom wrote down both words. Jonas stood up. "There are two bridges," he said. "The old stone bridge at South Meadow, and a wooden bridge near the station. The wooden one is already weak." Erik marked both places on the map.

Elin drew a red line along the river. It ended at the southern farms.

They agreed to send a warning to South Meadow. Elin wrote a short message that did not frighten people without good reason: "Possible high water from the glacier. Keep animals and supplies away from the river. Be ready to move uphill." Jonas sent it with a farmer who was leaving town with a horse. He also arranged for another person to tell the families farther east. Tom watched the horse move down the street. The warning was small, but it might save time later.

They needed to reach the station to learn what had happened. Jonas studied the weather and suggested a journey with two horses and a strong sled. He would guide them, Erik would bring scientific tools, and Elin would examine the ice. Tom wanted to carry a portable radio, although it was heavy. "If we find the station without power, we can still send a message," he said. He packed wire, a small battery, spare valves, headphones, and a notebook. He had repaired radios in warm workshops; now his work would happen in snow.

Before leaving, Elin looked at the map once more. The red line went past the farms and through the narrow lower valley. She drew a small circle around South Meadow. "The people there do not need a perfect explanation," she said. "They need enough truth to make a good decision." Erik folded the map and put it in the case. Outside, the sky had turned the colour of cold iron. Jonas checked the horses and pointed toward the mountain road. "We go while we can still see the track," he said.

CHAPTER 3

Across the White Plain

They left Hrafnvik just after breakfast. The sled carried the radio case, blankets, food, and a little stove. Jonas walked beside the first horse, while the others took turns riding on the sled. Snow made the world quiet. The town disappeared behind a low hill, and soon the only sounds were the horses' steps and the wooden runners moving over ice. Tom looked back once. The roofs of Hrafnvik were only small dark marks against the white ground.

The first part of the journey was easy. A frozen field led them to a line of rocks that Jonas knew well. But after an hour, the wind began to blow across the plain. Snow moved over the old track and filled the marks left by earlier travellers. Jonas stopped near a black stone and held up his hand. "From here, we do not follow what we see," he said. "We follow what we know." He pointed to a second stone almost hidden in snow. They turned left and continued.



Tom had never travelled so far in such weather. He kept his scarf close to his face and watched the horizon. Sometimes he thought he saw a building or a person ahead. When he blinked, it was only a dark rock or a cloud. Elin walked beside him for a while. "The snow changes distances," she said. "A hill can look like a small stone. A stone can look like a house." Tom smiled without much humour. "Then I am glad Jonas knows the road."

At midday they stopped behind a rocky wall and shared bread, cheese, and warm water from a flask. Erik opened his notebook. He wanted to compare the direction of the wind with his measurements from last year. But the pencil was too cold for his fingers. Elin held the book while he wrote. Tom checked the small radio battery. It was safe inside a padded box, but a loose wire could stop everything. He tied the case again with extra cloth.

Jonas returned from the top of a little rise. "There is water ahead," he said. Elin looked surprised. The stream near the road should have been frozen. They followed him to a place where the snow was dark and thin. Steam rose from a crack between two stones. Under it, water moved quickly. Erik took the temperature with a simple thermometer. The water was much warmer than the air. "This is not proof of a flood," he said. "But it is one more reason to take the message seriously."

The next hill brought another problem. One of the horses stopped and would not pull. Its hoof had slipped into a hidden hole, and the sled leaned dangerously. Jonas spoke softly to the animal. Tom and Erik took the heavy radio case off the sled while Elin moved the blankets. Working together, they pulled the sled free. The horse stood quietly, shaking its head. Nobody was hurt, but they had lost almost an hour. The day was

now growing short.

"We could return," Tom said. He did not want to be the reason someone was injured. Jonas looked toward the mountains. "We could," he agreed. "But if the station has lost its radio, the people there might be waiting for us. We must think carefully." Elin pointed to a low stone house on the far side of the plain. "The old sheep shelter is not far. We can sleep there and begin again at first light." Erik supported her plan. The others agreed.

They reached the shelter at dusk. Its roof held most of the snow out, and a small corner stayed dry. Jonas fed the horses while Tom made a little fire in the stove. Elin used the last light to draw the warm stream on their map. Erik examined the radio. For a moment, a weak voice seemed to rise from the receiver, but it disappeared under a wall of noise. Tom tried a different wire and waited. Nothing came. He wrote the time in his notebook, just as he had in the office.

As they prepared to sleep, Jonas told them that his father had once crossed the valley during a sudden warm winter. "The snow was still deep," he said, "but water came from places that had been dry for years." Elin listened carefully. Old stories were not measurements, yet they could tell a scientist where to look. She asked Jonas to show her the old river on the map. He placed his finger on the red line she had drawn. "There," he said. "That path is older than the road." Nobody spoke for a while.

CHAPTER 4

The Station Without a Voice

The next morning was bright but very cold. The four travellers left the shelter before the sun reached the hills. Snow hung on every stone like thick white cloth. Far ahead, a narrow aerial rose above a ridge. Tom pointed to it. "North Ridge," he said. They were close enough to see the station, but a deep hollow lay between them and the building. Jonas knew a path around the hollow. The horses followed him slowly, and the sled moved at an angle across the hard snow.

A small wooden bridge crossed the stream below the station. Its boards were dark with water. Jonas stopped before the first board and tested it with his staff. The wood moved under the pressure. "No horses," he said at once. They tied the animals to a sheltered rock and took only what they could carry. Tom put the portable radio on his back. Erik held the notebooks and tools, while Elin took the food and first-aid bag. They crossed one at a time, walking near the stronger side of the bridge.



The door of North Ridge was open a few inches. No light came from the windows. Tom called out twice, but nobody answered. Inside, a chair lay on its side and a cup had broken near the stove. Snow had blown across the floor through a gap beneath the door. A radio stood on the worktable, its front panel open. Several wires hung loose. There was no sound from the speaker. Tom touched the power switch and found that the battery was almost empty.

"Where are the scientists?" Erik asked. Two people had been working at the station: Dr. Marta Solberg and a younger researcher named Ari. Their coats were not in the room. On the wall, a calendar still showed February, but someone had marked today's date in red. Elin walked to the back door and saw footprints leading up the hill. The marks were partly filled with snow. They could not tell whether one person or two had made them. Jonas looked toward the ridge and frowned.

Tom opened the radio case and examined the broken connections. A wire had been pulled free near the battery. The aerial cable was also damaged. "Someone tried to repair it," he said. "These marks are from a tool, not from the weather." He did not know whether the repair had failed or someone had left in a hurry. In a drawer he found paper with radio times written neatly down the side. The last entry was from the previous night. Under it, one word had been written again and again: BRIDGE.

Erik found another notebook on a shelf. Its pages were damp, but the numbers were clear. The scientists had measured the water near the glacier every morning. During the last three days, its temperature had risen and its flow had grown stronger. On one page Dr. Solberg had written, "Do not use the lower road after dark." Elin took the notebook and compared its

numbers with her map. She wanted to know where the water went after it left the ice.

They searched the station carefully. There was no sign of a fight or an accident inside. Food remained in the cupboard. The beds had been used, and a lamp stood ready beside the back door. In the small workshop, Erik found a wooden marker with a red cloth tied to one end. Jonas recognized it. "We use these to show an unsafe path," he said. "Maybe the scientists went to warn someone near the upper bridge." Tom looked at the open door. The two people had not simply disappeared; they had gone somewhere with a purpose.

A sharp noise came from outside. At first Tom thought it was a branch breaking, but there were no trees near the building. The sound came again, deeper this time. They went outside and watched the far side of the valley. A small line of snow moved down a rock face. Then water burst from a dark opening below it. The stream was still far away, but the noise reached them clearly. Elin pressed the notebook against her coat. "The river is finding a new way," she said.

Ari's handwriting appeared on the final page of the notebook: "If the lower crossing fails, use the old northern path. Tell the village before the second night." Erik read the sentence aloud. Jonas looked from the hill to the sky. "We have little daylight," he said. "First we must find Marta and Ari. Then we must send a warning." Tom looked at the silent radio. It was the only machine in the valley that could reach the town quickly. He had brought his tools, but he could not yet make it speak.

CHAPTER 5

Footprints on the Ice

Jonas followed the footprints behind the station. Tom stayed close to him, carrying a coil of wire, while Elin and Erik walked beside the ridge. The path went uphill through loose stones and hard snow. In some places the footprints were clear; in others, the wind had erased them. Jonas studied the shape of the ground rather than the marks alone. He knew people avoided a steep part of the hill, even when the snow hid the reason. He turned along a lower line of rocks.

They came to a small measuring hut built beside the ice. Its roof was white, and a long wooden pole stood outside. A red cloth hung from the pole. Elin opened the door. Inside, Dr. Marta Solberg sat beside a young man with a bandage around his ankle. Marta looked tired but relieved. "You heard us," she said. Tom nodded. "Only a few words. We came as soon as we could." Ari tried to stand, but Marta asked him to remain seated.



Ari explained that he had slipped on the path the evening before. Marta helped him into the hut. She had tried to call the station with a small field telephone, but its wire had broken in the cold. They had left the main radio on low power, hoping the message would reach someone before the battery died. At the last moment, Marta had remembered the old emergency key. She used it to send short taps when speech was no longer possible. Tom thought of the sounds he had heard in Hrafnvik.

Marta spread a damp drawing across the table. For two weeks, warm water had been moving through a narrow opening below the glacier. The opening was becoming larger. The researchers feared that water was collecting behind a wall of ice and stones. "We cannot see the whole pool," Marta said. "But the sound has changed, and the stream below is stronger every hour." She pointed to a mark on the drawing. "If that wall breaks suddenly, the lower valley may flood."

Elin asked about the villages. Marta had already tried to reach South Meadow by the northern path, but Ari's fall had stopped them. "We marked the old bridge because it may be the first place the water reaches," she said. "If anyone goes there, they could be trapped." Jonas told her that a warning had left Hrafnvik the day before. Marta sighed with relief, yet she did not smile. A message to one village was not enough. Farms stood along several bends of the river.

Erik checked Ari's ankle. It was painful and swollen, but not broken. Ari could not walk quickly. The team needed to choose between helping him reach the station and going ahead to warn the village. For a moment everyone spoke at once. Then Elin asked them to stop. "We must use what each person can do," she said. "Jonas knows the safest path. Erik can care

for Ari. Tom can repair the radio. Marta and I can check the water." She made the choice sound simple, although the danger was not.

They began to return to North Ridge. Jonas and Erik supported Ari on the steep parts of the path. Tom carried the notebooks, and Marta walked beside Elin. Near the edge of the ice, Elin stopped to listen. A low sound came from beneath her feet, almost like a train moving far away. "That is water," Marta said quietly. Tom felt an uncomfortable coldness that was not caused by the weather. He suddenly understood why the last radio message had been so short.

At the station, Tom laid his tools on the table and removed the back of the receiver. The battery could not be repaired with a screwdriver. It needed charging, and the little generator in the workshop had a broken belt. His portable battery would run the set for only a short time. "Then we must choose our words carefully," he said. Elin wrote down the names of the places at risk. Marta checked every name against the map. No one wanted to send a warning to the wrong village.

Before Tom connected the battery, a faint shout came from outside. Jonas stood in the snow, pointing south. A line of grey water was now moving across the lower rocks. The stream had grown wider since morning. It was no longer a question of whether the river had changed. The change was happening before their eyes. Tom looked at the list of villages and pushed the radio switch toward ON.

CHAPTER 6

Warm Water, Cold Stone

The radio made a soft hum. Tom placed one hand on the tuning dial and waited for the valve to warm. He called Hrafnvik twice, but he heard no answer. The aerial wire hung too low outside, and part of it touched the roof. Jonas went out with a rope and lifted the cable as high as he could. Tom called again. This time, a voice came through the noise. It was Sara, the young operator at the town office. "North Ridge, I hear you. Your signal is weak. Speak slowly."

Tom gave Elin the microphone. She read the warning in clear, short sentences. "Water from the glacier is rising. Move people and animals away from the lower river. Do not use the old bridge. Please confirm." Sara repeated the message word for word. Then she said she would send it to the farms by telephone and messenger. Erik checked the time. They had finally given the town useful information, but nobody knew when the river would reach the road.



The battery grew weaker. Marta suggested that they use the radio only once more after making a careful measurement. She and Elin went to a safe place above the river with a rope, a thermometer, and a marked stick. They did not step onto the ice. Instead, they compared the level of the water with a rock they had measured the previous autumn. The water was already higher than the old mark. Steam rose from its surface in the freezing air.

"It is warm, but not hot," Elin said. She held the thermometer in her glove while Marta recorded the number. The warm water could come from deeper underground, where rocks carried heat. It might also have been trapped beneath the glacier for some time. They could not be certain without more study. "We do not need to know every part of the cause today," Marta said. "We need to know how quickly the water is moving."

They returned to the station, where Erik had placed Ari near the stove. Ari was drawing a map of the river from memory. He had walked the lower valley many times in summer. On the map he marked a narrow place between two cliffs. "If water fills this gap, the level will rise quickly behind it," he explained. Jonas knew the place. "The old crossing is just below it," he said. "And the farm road runs very close to the river there." He took a pencil and marked a safer road over higher ground.

The team agreed to send a second warning, this time with the route people should use. Tom connected the battery again. It had only enough power for a few minutes. He asked Sara to listen carefully, then gave her the name of the high road. Sara repeated the words. Tom asked her to send a message back when every family in South Meadow had received the warning. But before she could answer, the signal disappeared.

For a moment Tom thought his equipment had failed. He opened the case, touched each connection, and checked the meter. The needle sat almost at zero. The battery was empty. He looked at the broken generator in the workshop. The rubber belt had split, and there was no spare belt on the shelf. He could repair the radio, but not give it power. "We have sent what we can," he said. "Now we must help the people who may still be on the road."

Jonas suggested taking the sled to the northern path. Erik did not want to leave Ari alone, so he and Marta stayed at the station. Elin joined Tom and Jonas. They carried blankets, food, and a lantern, and they made sure their route stayed far above the river. When they crossed the ridge, Tom looked back at the aerial on the little building. It stood against the sky like a thin black pencil. He wished it could speak for them all day, but its silence forced them to use their feet.

At the top of the northern path, they heard a deep crack. A piece of ice fell into the river far below. Water rose against the stones, then carried the broken ice away. Jonas took off his hat and looked at the valley. "The bridge will not last," he said. They moved faster. Beyond the next hill, several small houses were waiting near the river, and the people inside did not know how little time remained.

CHAPTER 7

The Village by the River

South Meadow looked peaceful when they first saw it. A little smoke came from the roofs, and snow lay on the fences beside the houses. But people were already working outside. A farmer led two cows up the hill. A woman carried blankets to a wagon. A boy ran from door to door with a note in his hand. The warning from Hrafnvik had arrived. Jonas waved to the people, and several came to meet him near the church.

The village teacher, Mrs. Helga, showed Elin the note. Its words were short and correct, but it did not explain how close the danger might be. "Some families are ready to leave," she said. "Others think the river is still frozen, so there is no danger." Elin asked to speak to everyone in the schoolroom. She did not want to frighten them, but she had seen the water herself. Tom helped Jonas move the sled to the high road while the people gathered.



Elin stood beside a map on the wall. She explained that water could travel beneath ice, even when the surface looked white and quiet. She told the villagers about the warm stream, the rising level, and the measurements taken by the scientists. "We cannot tell you the exact hour," she said. "But waiting by the lower river is unsafe. Please take the high road before dark." A man in a wool coat asked how she could know about water she could not see. Elin answered patiently. "Because we can measure the water that comes out, and we can compare it with yesterday."

A few people nodded. Others looked at their shoes. Old Mr. Olaf, whose farm stood closest to the river, did not want to leave. His daughter was away in Hrafnvik, and he was worried she would not find him if she returned. Tom offered to write a note for his door. Mrs. Helga promised to carry the note to the town. After a long silence, Olaf agreed to pack a small bag. "I built that house forty years ago," he said. "I hope it is still there tomorrow." Nobody promised him it would be.

The move began slowly. Jonas took charge of the animals and the wagons. Children carried small bags, and adults helped older neighbours across the snow. Elin checked the path to make sure it was above the river. Tom found that the school had a simple field telephone connected to a farm farther south. He tried it, but the line was dead. He could see ice on the wire outside. Without the radio, they had to send people with messages along the road.

A woman named Anna told Tom that her brother was working at the old stone bridge. He had been repairing the rail that morning and might not have heard the warning. Jonas knew the man and offered to go. Elin stopped him. "We cannot send someone across a dangerous road without

checking it," she said. They chose a high footpath that overlooked the bridge from a safe distance. Tom and Jonas went together, carrying a lantern and a red cloth.

From the hill, they could see the river. Dark water ran between pieces of ice. The old bridge stood across it, but one end had begun to bend. A man in a grey coat was working near the southern rail. Jonas shouted his name. The wind carried the sound away. Tom waved the red cloth with both hands. The man looked up and stepped back. Jonas pointed toward the high path. After a moment, the man understood and ran away from the bridge.

They watched him reach the road above the stream. Then the water struck the bridge with a heavy sound. A piece of wood broke free and travelled downstream. The man sat down in the snow, unable to speak for a moment. Jonas helped him stand. "The village is moving uphill," he explained. "Come with us." Together they walked toward South Meadow. They had not rescued someone from the river, but they had stopped him from stepping onto the bridge again.

By sunset, most people were safe on the high road. Mrs. Helga counted families in a notebook. One group was still missing: a mother, her two children, and an old man from the far side of the valley. They had been travelling toward the village that morning. No one knew where they were. Elin looked at the darkening sky and felt the weight of the unfinished list. The danger had not ended with the broken bridge.

Tom and Jonas returned to the high road with the villagers. They searched the nearby track for the missing family, but the wind had covered every footprint. There was no light from the houses below. Elin asked two

strong farmers to help search from the safe side of the ridge. She would not let anyone enter the low valley. The river could move faster than a person could run. They called out until their voices grew tired, but there was no answer.

At the schoolhouse, Mrs. Helga brought warm soup and blankets. The children who had reached safety sat together beside the stove. Tom looked at them and thought of the two children still missing. He asked whether the village had a radio. Mrs. Helga showed him a small receiver used for weather news, but it could not send messages. Tom studied it anyway. The set had a dry battery and a length of spare wire. They were not enough for a strong signal, yet they gave him an idea.

The school receiver could not become a full transmitter in one evening. But Tom remembered the emergency key on the station radio. If he could return to North Ridge and give that set a little power, it might send a few short signals. He told Elin his plan. She looked doubtful. "The road is worse now," she said. "And we do not know if the aerial is still standing." Tom understood the danger, but he also knew the missing family might have reached a shelter with a radio. An emergency message could ask every nearby station to listen.

Jonas made a different suggestion. The farm on the northern hill had an old telephone line that sometimes worked when the lower line failed. It was not far, and they could reach it without going near the river. Elin agreed to try the farm first. Tom wanted to leave at once, but Jonas asked everyone to take five minutes for food and dry gloves. "Cold people make bad decisions," he said. Nobody argued. After eating, they followed him to the hill.

At the farm, a tired woman opened the door and led them to the telephone. Tom turned the handle and listened. At first he heard only a click. He tried again. Then a voice answered from Hrafnvik. It was Sara. She sounded as relieved as Tom felt. He told her that the lower bridge was damaged, most villagers were safe, and one family was missing. Sara promised to send the information to every working radio station along the coast and to nearby farms with telephone lines.

"We also have a message for you," Sara said. "North Ridge tried to call again, but the sound stopped. A short signal may have come from somewhere east of the old bridge. We are checking." Tom asked her to repeat the direction. East of the bridge was where the missing family might have travelled. He wrote the words on a page and gave it to Jonas. Sara added that people from Hrafnvik were coming with extra horses and blankets. She warned them not to use the lower road.

They returned to the schoolhouse with the news. Elin divided the search into small groups, each with a clear limit. One group would look along the high road. Another would check a stone shelter east of the bridge. A third would stay at the school and prepare food for anyone who came back. Tom went with Jonas to the stone shelter, carrying a lantern. Elin remained with the villagers to keep the search safe and organised.

The path was narrow but high above the river. Jonas walked first and tested the snow with his staff. At the shelter, Tom found a small piece of cloth tied to the door. Inside were three empty cups and a warm place near the stove. Someone had been there recently. On the floor lay a child's mitten. Tom picked it up carefully. The family had found shelter, but they had not stayed. Jonas saw tracks leading north, away from the river. That

was good news.

They followed the tracks a short distance and heard a child calling in the dark. Tom raised his lantern. Beyond a low rock stood the missing family, cold and tired but safe. The old man had hurt his knee, so they could not walk quickly. Jonas gave him his arm. Tom wrapped the children in spare blankets. They moved slowly toward the high road, and when the schoolhouse lamps appeared in the distance, Tom felt that every small light was a promise kept.

CHAPTER 8

The Last Radio Message

The missing family returned to the schoolhouse shortly before midnight. Mrs. Helga counted everyone again. This time there were no empty spaces beside the names. Outside, the river still made a terrible noise, and nobody knew whether the old bridge remained standing. But the people were on high ground. They had food, blankets, and a safe road toward Hrafnvik. For the first time that day, Elin allowed herself to sit down.

Sara called from the town telephone before dawn. The warning had reached the last farms, and help was on its way. She also had news from North Ridge. Erik had repaired part of the station generator with a strip of leather from an old tool bag. It could give the battery a little charge, but only for a few minutes. He wanted Tom to return and check the transmitter before the battery was used. "We may need one final message," Sara said.



Elin and Jonas had already planned to return by the upper path. They left the schoolhouse in the care of Mrs. Helga and the arriving helpers. Tom travelled with them, carrying his tools. The weather had improved, but the snow on the hills was still deep. From the ridge they could see that the river had changed the shape of the valley. A new channel cut across the lower ground. The old stone bridge was gone. Only the higher road remained.

At North Ridge, Marta met them at the door. Ari was resting, and Erik was working beside the generator. A short belt made from leather moved around two wheels. When Erik turned the handle, a small meter on the wall moved too. "Not much power," he said, "but perhaps enough for our final report." Tom checked the aerial, connected the transmitter, and asked everyone to keep quiet. The radio began to hum. It was a familiar sound, and he had never been so glad to hear it.

Elin stood with the notebook in her hand. She had measured the water again on the way back. Its level was no longer rising at the same speed, but danger remained near the damaged roads. She wrote a message with only the facts they knew. Tom sent it in short sentences: "North Ridge to Hrafnvik. All known families are safe. Lower bridge destroyed. Keep lower road closed. Use high road only. River still dangerous. More measurements tomorrow. Please confirm."

At first, the radio answered with rough noise. Then Sara's voice came through, clear enough for every person in the room to understand. "Hrafnvik confirms. We have the message. Help has reached South Meadow. Thank you, North Ridge." Tom looked at Erik, who was still turning the generator handle. Elin smiled at Marta. The message was not a great speech. It did not solve every problem. But it told the town what it

needed to know.

The radio grew weaker. Tom sent one last line before the battery stopped: "Remember the high road." Then the sound faded, and the room became quiet. Marta touched the notebook on the table. "That is the last message this battery will send," she said. Tom removed his headphones. For two days he had been afraid of silence. Now this silence felt different. Everyone had heard the warning, and no one was waiting alone for help.

Erik thanked Tom for carrying the portable radio through the snow. Tom shook his head. "The radio mattered," he said, "but so did the map, the guide, the measurements, and the people who carried messages from house to house." Jonas, who had been silent for a long time, laughed softly. "And the warm soup," he added. They all smiled. It was not a joke about the danger. It was a small reminder that people needed ordinary kindness, even during extraordinary days.

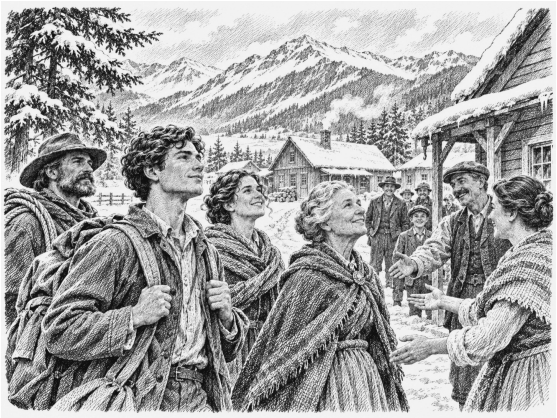
Before leaving, Elin wrote the final water level in the station notebook. She placed a red line below the latest number and left space for the next day's measurement. The page did not say that the problem was finished. It simply showed what they knew at that moment. She closed the book and looked through the window. A thin line of morning light had reached the mountain. The valley was still difficult and strange, but it was no longer silent.

CHAPTER 9

A Clear Morning

Three days later, the road to South Meadow was open again from the north. The lower bridge had been destroyed, and the farms near it had been damaged. Some fences were gone, and one small shed had fallen into the river. But every family had reached safety. People from Hrafnvik brought wood, food, blankets, and tools. Others helped move animals back to the higher fields. The work was slow, and nobody pretended that the village would be the same by evening.

Tom returned to the radio office in town. The room looked smaller than he remembered. The same chair stood beside the desk, and the same lamp lit the thick message book. He opened it to the night of the first call. There were the words he had written: "Water ... under ... ice." At the time, they had seemed too small to be useful. Now he could see the long road they had started. A short message had led to a map, a journey, and many people working together.



Sara came into the room carrying fresh paper. She wanted to copy the emergency messages for the town record. "They should be kept," she said. "If another warning comes, we can remember what worked and what did not." Tom agreed. He helped her write the times in order and marked the places where the signal had disappeared. He also recorded the mistakes: the damaged aerial, the empty battery, and the village telephone line that failed in the storm.

Elin spent the next week at North Ridge with Marta and Erik. They repaired the measuring poles and watched the river every day. The warm water continued to flow, but the level slowly fell. The scientists could not say exactly when the next change would happen. They wrote careful notes and planned better warning routes for the farms. "A good scientist must be ready to change an answer when new facts arrive," Elin told Ari. He smiled and added the day's numbers to the book.

Jonas helped build a temporary crossing on the high road. People asked him how he had found the safe paths in deep snow. He told them that maps were useful, but a guide also learned from years of walking and listening. Then he surprised them by saying that he wanted to learn how to read the new water measurements. "If Elin can understand the river from numbers," he said, "I should understand them too." Elin promised to teach him when the work was done.

One afternoon, Mrs. Helga brought her schoolchildren to the Hrafnvik radio office. She asked Tom to show them the equipment. The children stood around the desk, looking at the headphones and the large dials. A little girl asked whether the machine could hear every person in the world. Tom laughed. "No," he said. "Sometimes we cannot hear a person on the

next mountain. The signal can be weak, and the weather can be strong. But we can learn to listen better."

He let each child hear a safe, ordinary weather report. Then he explained how an operator wrote down messages and asked people to repeat important words. "If you are not sure what you heard, do not guess," he said. "Ask again, or say that you do not know." Mrs. Helga nodded. The children began writing little messages of their own, and the office filled with quiet voices and the scratch of pencils.

That evening, Tom walked to the harbour with Elin. Snow still rested on the boats, but the sky was clear. Across the water, the mountains stood dark and peaceful. Elin told him that she would return to North Ridge in spring to continue her work. "We need better records," she said. "And a better radio." Tom promised to help repair the station properly. He was no longer afraid of a long journey across the snow, although he respected the weather more than before.

At the end of the pier, a bell sounded from a fishing boat. Tom stopped to listen. It was a simple sound with no secret meaning. He thought about the night when a few broken words had crossed the mountains. He had wanted a complete message, a clear voice, and an easy answer. Instead, he had received only enough information to begin. He understood something now: a message does not have to be long to matter, but people must listen carefully and act together. He turned toward the lights of town and walked home.

Vocabulary - 40 Useful Words

These words help you understand the story. Read the meanings and find the words in the chapters.

No.	Word	Type	Meaning
1	aerial	n.	a wire or pole that helps a radio send or receive signals
2	battery	n.	a device that stores electrical power
3	bridge	n.	a structure that crosses water or a road
4	cable	n.	a strong wire used for electricity or signals
5	channel	n.	a path through which water moves
6	confirm	v.	to say that something is correct or has been received
7	crack	n.	a narrow break in rock, ice, or another surface
8	danger	n.	the possibility that someone may be hurt
9	dial	n.	a round control on a machine
10	emergency	n.	a serious situation that needs action quickly
11	equipment	n.	tools and machines used for work
12	field	n.	an open area of land
13	flood	n.	water covering land that is usually dry
14	generator	n.	a machine that produces electricity
15	glacier	n.	a very large body of ice moving slowly over land
16	guide	n.	a person who shows others the safe way
17	headphones	n.	equipment worn over the ears to hear sound
18	ice	n.	water that has become solid because of cold
19	measure	v.	to find the size, level, or amount of something

No.	Word	Type	Meaning
20	message	n.	information sent from one person to another
21	meter	n.	a tool that measures something
22	notebook	n.	a small book used for writing notes
23	operator	n.	a person who controls a machine or communication system
24	receiver	n.	a machine used to hear radio signals
25	repair	v.	to make a damaged thing work again
26	research	n.	careful work to learn more about something
27	ridge	n.	a long, narrow area of high ground
28	river	n.	moving water that flows across land
29	route	n.	the way people travel from one place to another
30	safe	adj.	not likely to cause danger or injury
31	shelter	n.	a place that protects people from bad weather
32	signal	n.	a sound or other sign that carries information
33	snow	n.	small pieces of ice that fall from clouds
34	station	n.	a place where people work or operate equipment
35	stream	n.	a small river
36	temperature	n.	the degree of heat or cold
37	transmitter	n.	a device that sends radio signals
38	valley	n.	low land between hills or mountains
39	warning	n.	information that tells people about possible danger
40	wire	n.	a thin metal line that carries signals or electricity

Comprehension Questions

Chapter 1

1. Where was Tom working when he heard the strange voice?

2. Which three words did he write in his notebook?

3. Why was North Ridge difficult to contact?

Chapter 2

1. What did Elin mark with her red pencil?

2. What warning did the team send to South Meadow?

3. Why did Jonas choose to travel by sled?

Chapter 3

1. What did the team discover beside the road?

2. Why did the horse stop?

3. Where did the travellers spend the night?

Chapter 4

1. What was wrong with the station radio?

2. Where did the footprints lead?

3. What had Ari written in the notebook?

Chapter 5

1. Why could Ari not walk quickly?

2. What did Marta say about the water under the glacier?

3. How did the team plan to use each person's skills?

Chapter 6

1. What did Sara confirm over the radio?

2. Why could Tom not send a long second message?

3. What changed near the river?

Chapter 7

1. Why did Elin call a meeting at the village school?

2. What happened at the old bridge?

3. Where did Jonas and Tom find the missing family?

4. Why did Tom try the farm telephone?

Chapter 8

1. What did the final radio message say?

2. Why was the high road important?

3. What did Tom learn about teamwork?

Chapter 9

1. What did Tom show the schoolchildren?

2. Why did the researchers continue their measurements?

3. What is the story's main lesson?

True or False?

Write T for true or F for false. Correct the false sentences.

1. Tom received a clear, complete radio message on the first night. _____

2. Elin marked the possible danger along the river on a map. _____

3. The team travelled to North Ridge by train. _____

4. Jonas helped the group find paths hidden by snow. _____

5. The station battery was nearly empty. _____

6. Marta and Ari were waiting safely at the town office. _____

7. Elin and Marta measured the river from a safe place. _____

8. The first warning said that the old bridge was safe. _____

9. Every family in South Meadow moved without any questions. _____

10. Tom and Jonas found the missing family near a stone shelter. _____

11. Erik repaired the generator with a strip of leather. _____

12. The last radio message told people to use the lower road. _____

13. The people of Hrafnvik helped South Meadow after the flood. _____

14. Tom taught the children to guess when they could not hear a message. _____

15. The scientists planned to keep studying the glacier. _____

Vocabulary Practice

A Choose the correct word

1. The radio needed a new _____ to send the call. (battery / garden)

2. The river rose and caused a _____. (flood / lesson)

3. Jonas was the mountain _____. (guide / cook)

4. Elin wanted to _____ the water level. (measure / paint)

5. The village needed a clear _____. (warning / holiday)

6. The station was beside a large _____. (glacier / library)

7. Tom tried to _____ the transmitter. (repair / forget)

8. The _____ carried the sound to the town. (signal / blanket)

9. The old _____ was damaged by water. (bridge / window)

10. The team chose a safer _____. (route / colour)

B Make a sentence

Write one new sentence with each word: station, safe, message, research, stream, shelter.

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

6. _____

Discussion Questions

1. Would you have travelled to the station after the first message? Why?

2. Who made the most important decision in the story? Explain your answer.

3. What can a scientist learn by comparing measurements from different days?

4. How can a guide help people when maps are not enough?

5. Why is it dangerous to make promises without enough information?

6. Why did some people at South Meadow not want to leave?

7. How did the radio help people who never met Tom?

8. Which part of the story was the most exciting for you?

9. What should people do when they do not understand an important message?

10. What would you change about the team's journey?

Writing Task

Write 120-150 words. Imagine that you are Tom, writing a letter to a friend after the journey. Explain where you went, what happened, who helped, and what you learned.

Try to use the past simple, because, when, before, after, and at least six new words from the glossary.

Final Test

Choose the best answer (a, b, or c).

1. Where did Tom hear the first signal?

a) At the harbour b) At the radio office c) At the station

2. What did the voice mention?

a) Water under ice b) A lost boat c) A broken window

3. Who knew the mountain paths?

a) Sara b) Jonas c) Ari

4. What did Elin use to show the possible danger?

a) A red line on a map b) A photograph c) A newspaper

5. How did the team travel?

a) By aeroplane b) By sled and horses c) By ship

6. Why did they stop at the shelter?

a) To sleep safely b) To buy food c) To meet visitors

7. What did they find at North Ridge?

a) An empty, silent station b) A large hospital c) A new school

8. Who was injured?

a) Ari b) Sara c) Tom

9. What happened to the river?

a) It became stronger b) It dried completely c) It turned into a road

10. How did Tom give the town a warning?

a) By radio b) By painting a sign c) By sending a boat

11. What was wrong with the battery?

a) It was nearly empty b) It was too big c) It was new

12. Where did the villagers move?

a) To higher ground b) To the lower bridge c) Into the river

13. Who helped count the villagers?

a) Mrs. Helga b) Dr. Solberg c) A fisherman

14. What happened to the old bridge?

a) It was destroyed b) It became wider c) It was painted

15. Where was the missing family found?

a) On the high path b) In the town office c) Inside the river

16. What was used to repair the generator?

a) A leather strip b) A glass bottle c) A newspaper

17. What did the last message tell people?

a) Keep the lower road open b) Use the high road c) Forget the warning

18. What did Tom teach the children?

a) Ask again instead of guessing b) Never write notes c) Radio can hear everyone

19. What did the researchers continue to do?

a) Measure water b) Build a new hotel c) Study fishing nets

20. What is one important theme of the story?

a) Careful listening and teamwork b) Winning a race c) Finding buried treasure

Answer Key

Before You Read – Key Words

signal - c; glacier - d; warning - e; guide - b; repair - a.

True or False

1. F - Rewrite the sentence using information from the story.

2. T - Elin marked the possible danger along the river on a map.

3. F - Rewrite the sentence using information from the story.

4. T - Jonas helped the group find paths hidden by snow.

5. T - The station battery was nearly empty.

6. F - Rewrite the sentence using information from the story.

7. T - Elin and Marta measured the river from a safe place.

8. F - Rewrite the sentence using information from the story.

9. F - Rewrite the sentence using information from the story.

10. T - Tom and Jonas found the missing family near a stone shelter.

11. T - Erik repaired the generator with a strip of leather.

12. F - Rewrite the sentence using information from the story.

13. T - The people of Hrafnvik helped South Meadow after the flood.

14. F - Rewrite the sentence using information from the story.

15. T - The scientists planned to keep studying the glacier.

Vocabulary Practice

1 battery; 2 flood; 3 guide; 4 measure; 5 warning; 6 glacier; 7 repair; 8 signal; 9 bridge; 10 route.

Final Test

1. b 2. a 3. b 4. a 5. b 6. a 7. a 8. a 9. a 10. a

11. a 12. a 13. a 14. a 15. a 16. a 17. b 18. a 19. a 20. a

Comprehension Answers

Answers should agree with the events in the text. Accept clear, correct A2-level sentences, even when different words are used.

Chapter 1: Tom was in the radio office; the message said water under ice; the station was remote and the radio was weak.

Chapter 2: The line followed the river toward South Meadow; villagers were told to prepare to move uphill; Jonas planned a sled journey.

Chapter 3: They found warmer water; the horse slipped; they slept in a stone shelter.

Chapter 4: The radio had little battery power and damaged wires; footprints went uphill; the notebook warned against the lower road.

Chapter 5: Ari hurt his ankle; Marta feared rising water under the ice; each traveller took work suited to their skills.

Chapter 6: Sara confirmed the warning; the battery failed; water rose near the rocks.

Chapter 7: Elin explained the danger; the old bridge broke; the family was found on the high path; the farm telephone reached Hrafnvik.

Chapter 8: The message said all known families were safe and the lower road must stay closed; the high road stayed above the water; teamwork kept people safe.

Chapter 9: Tom showed radio equipment; the researchers needed more facts; careful listening and honest communication matter.

WorldVoice Library

The Last Radio Message

Iceland, 1932

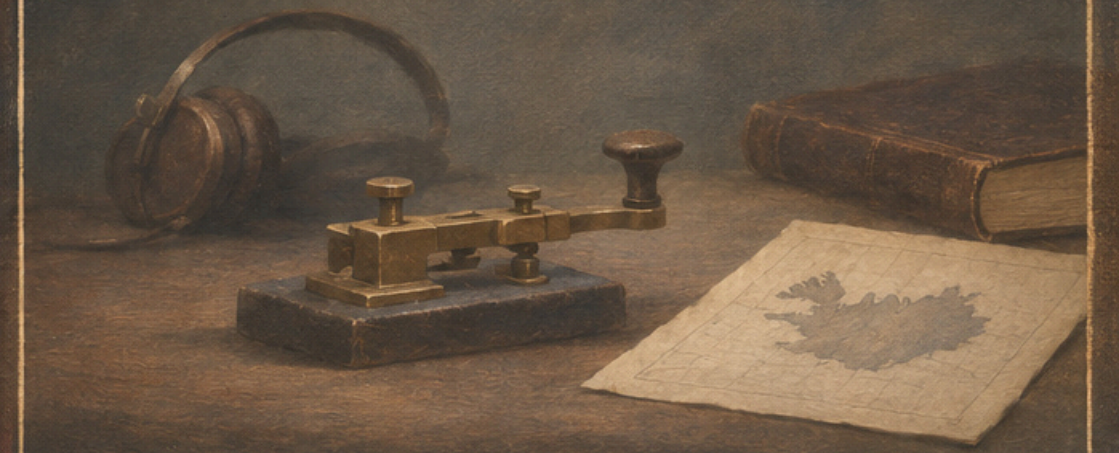
This graded reader includes:

- A thrilling scientific story
- Nine illustrated chapters
- A glossary of key vocabulary (40 words)
- Comprehension and discussion questions
- A writing task

English Level

A2

Elementary



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